

WHAT WE HAVE LOST

Even though epidemiologists predicted for many years that an outbreak such as COVID-19 would eventually occur, the global pandemic still took the general public and leadership around the world by surprise. Reluctantly, we have been forced into a drastic new way of living. And we've had to walk away from much of our regular life. What have you lost this past month? I'm sure you don't have to think for very long to come up with your list. Similar losses are on all our minds:

"My team had a game scheduled tonight."

"We would have been on vacation."

"I should have been at prom."

"I haven't hung out with my friends in weeks!"

These and other losses add up, making it difficult to face each day.

Shifting Sand

With every domino that falls, we experience more and more loss, which inevitably leaves us feeling less and less hopeful. There is no shortage of pain, sadness, and difficulty. We see it in the news. We hear it from our friends and family. We feel it in our hearts. In some ways, it's as though the ground has shifted beneath us. Continuing change and loss has left us wondering what to expect—next week, next month, and even three months from now.

And Yet . . .

Believe it or not, there is still good reason to hope! God has not changed! Being forced to let go allows us to start over and start fresh. We have the chance to begin again and view life through a new set of eyes, to evaluate in whom and in what we place our trust and hope. Still, we definitely need to acknowledge our disappointments. Chaos provides an opportunity to name our losses and to reconnect with our true source of hope. Even in our distress, God invites us deeper into relationship. Let us embrace the chaos and move closer and closer to the One who loves us dearly throughout all our experiences.

He isn't here, because he's been raised from the dead,
just as he said. —Matthew 28:6a

TIP FOR THIS ISSUE

Everyone grieves in a personal way, but hearing from others about similar grief experiences can bring relief. Use this lesson to prompt honest discussion about our individual and collective losses. Then, use the activities, Scripture, and questions to help rebuild hope and faith.

Be sensitive to those who may be dealing with the death of loved ones as a result of current circumstances or other losses in the not-so-distant past. Pray for guidance and trust God to lead your conversations.



TEACHER BIBLE PREP

We can be certain that by taking on Jesus' yoke, we will find a true hope in the One who will never change or leave us.

MY HOPE IS IN THE LORD

Question of the Day: What change is most difficult for you?

Purpose: To help teens cope with the grief of unrealized expectations.

Cultural Connection: COVID-19 forcing us to change almost everything about our lives for the near future

Topic: Hope

A COMMON GRIEF

John 20:26-30

After eight days his disciples were again in a house and Thomas was with them. Even though the doors were locked, Jesus entered and stood among them. He said, "Peace be with you." — John 20:26

Commentary:

It had been more than a week since Jesus' death, and the disciples were still in a tailspin. They had spent nearly three years with Jesus—learning from him, studying his ways, and following his every step. He had provided for them, and he was the one in whom they placed their hope. But their hope was most likely in a savior of a geopolitical nature, someone they believed would deliver them from an oppressive Roman rule. When Jesus was crucified, the disciples' hopes were crushed and they did not know what to do. We can take great comfort in the first words Jesus spoke to them, "Peace be with you."

Questions to think about:

- ▶ What did the disciples lose? (*a friend and constant companion; the expectation of a political messiah; a tangible, constantly visible leader; an available source of answers and guidance; and much more*)
- ▶ Imagine yourselves in that upper room with the disciples. Their whole lives revolved around following Jesus. They had left everything for him and the hope of a revolution he might instigate. What do you think you might have been feeling?
- ▶ How are those feelings similar to what we are experiencing now? How are they different?

STRONGHOLD

Psalms 62:5-8

*Oh, I must find rest in God only,
because my hope comes from him!
Only God is my rock and my salvation—
my stronghold!—I will not be shaken. — Psalm 62:5*

Commentary:

King David is believed to be the author of Psalm 62, in which he expressed his feelings to God and then reaffirmed his faith. Prayer can help release our tensions in times of emotional stress, which is exactly what we see in this passage. Trusting God to be our rock, salvation, and fortress will change our entire outlook on life. We do not have to be held captive by resentment from the disappointment of others or unrealized expectations. If we rest in God's strength, nothing will be able to shake us.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ What line in this psalm most speaks to you?
- ▶ What is something in which people your age commonly put their hope?
- ▶ In what or whom do you tend to put your hope?

NEW YOKE

Matthew 11:28-30

*Come to me, all you who are struggling hard and carrying heavy loads, and I will give you rest. Put on my yoke, and learn from me. I'm gentle and humble. And you will find rest for yourselves. My yoke is easy to bear, and my burden is light.
—Matthew 11:28-30*

TEACHER BIBLE PREP



Commentary:

A person may carry any number of heavy burdens. In this passage, as Jesus addresses the crowds, it is likely that he was referring to sin, excessive demands of religious leaders, oppression and persecution, or weariness in the search for God. Jesus provides rest from all of these burdens and more. The gift of rest from Jesus is love, healing, and peace with God. It is not a promise to end all labor; nor is it a promise to end hardship. We can be certain that by taking on Jesus' yoke, we will find a true hope in the One who will never change or leave us.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ From what do you need rest?
- ▶ What burdens are you still carrying?
- ▶ What burdens do you need to release?

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DEVOTION: WHAT WE EXPECT

No one minds a good surprise, the kind where you receive unexpected adoration or you win an award. Who would complain about that good fortune? However, when we're surprised with bad news or the loss of something dear to us, we don't cope nearly as well. We are creatures of habit, and it's nearly impossible to fully expect the unexpected. Our list of unforeseen possibilities is limited by what we've already experienced personally or learned about from the stories of those around us.

In his Sermon on the Mount, Jesus proclaimed some unexpected truths:

"Happy are people who are hopeless, because the kingdom of heaven is theirs. Happy are people who grieve, because they will be made glad" (Matthew 5:3-4).

Jesus reminds us that when we hit bottom and are wrecked with loss, we are gifted new eyes to see the true beauty of God. We learn to rebuild our reality, trusting once again in the One who is worthy, dependable, and just.

In spite of all our losses these past few weeks (and more likely in the weeks to come), may you be filled again with God's renewing spirit of faith, love, and hope.



The Sermon on the Mount, artist rendering by Jan Brueghel the Elder, 1898, Flemish painting, oil on copper. Brueghel depicts Christ standing at a rustic podium near the crowd's center, identified by a pale yellow halo.

NEXT WEEK: To underscore the weirdness of the weirdest Easter you can remember, next week in LINC we'll talk about Easter *the week after Easter*.

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OUR ONE TRUE HOPE

Getting Ready: Arrange a day and time for your group to video conference and, if possible, send the link a few days prior to the meeting. Suggest students read all of the Scripture passages before you meet and gather the following items before your video call begins: a Bible, paper and pen or pencil, and their running shoes. Gather paper, pencil, and a dice for yourself. Also, compile a list of common household items that most students can access at home (such as dental floss, tooth pick, basketball, oregano, plunger, apple, striped sock, a parent/sibling/pet, a nickel, 9v battery, and so on). Email Youth Page 6 ahead of time to students or be ready to show the page on your video screen.

OPEN

So, Seek and Find (5 minutes)

Begin your gathering in a fun and competitive way by sending students on an in-home scavenger hunt. Explain to teens that you will call out one item at a time (from the list you prepared earlier). The first teen to return with the item in hand and show it on the video feed wins that round. The person with the most winning rounds wins the game.

EXPLORE

Talk Topic 1: True Loss (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

The lively opening activity likely helped your group open up and engage in conversation. Now, read aloud or summarize the cultural connection on Page 1 for the group. Then, from the following sentence starters, choose those that best match with your age group to explore Talk Topic 1.

Transition by saying: “Whether we realize it or not, all of us are dealing with loss because of our experiences the past few weeks. I’d love to hear more from you individually, so

let’s try this for starters. One at a time, finish this sentence.” Say aloud one or more of the following:

- ▶ The one thing I miss most is . . .
- ▶ This week I would have been/should have been . . .
- ▶ I never thought . . .

Explore any commonalities expressed and thank the group for sharing. Say: “We all are definitely dealing with loss; we’re grieving from not being able to live life as we expected. As we look at our first Scripture, consider this question: Did you ever think about how hard it was for the disciples to deal with losing Jesus? It doesn’t seem like they thought he was ever going to be arrested or killed. Let’s check out our first verse.” Read aloud or ask a teen to read the Scripture. Present the commentary for Talk Topic 1 in Teacher Bible Prep, before asking and talking about the questions provided there. Then ask and talk about this additional question:

- ▶ What would make life more challenging for you or your family in the nation’s current situation?

High School Option

Transition by saying: “I needed a fun game. Did you? Lately, it seems as if there’s nothing but bad news and disappointments. Our cultural connection is about our individual and collective loss. Listen to this.” Read aloud part or all of Page 1 to fully introduce the topic. Then, invite the students to share from their perspective by completing the following sentence starters:

- ▶ My biggest disappointment since this pandemic began is . . .
- ▶ If I had one more week of going to school this year, I would make sure to . . .
- ▶ I never thought I wouldn’t be able to . . .
- ▶ I am most worried about . . .

While listening to students, look for any common responses you might explore to show a deeper, shared experience. Then, call on someone to read aloud the John passage before presenting the commentary and discussion questions in Teacher Bible Prep. Follow up by asking and talking about the final question below:

- ▶ Before this pandemic, when did you experience the most disappointment in life?

Talk Topic 2: True Source (15 minutes)

Combined Middle School and High School Option

Use Wheel of Misfortune for a fun way to keep teens engaged. Hold up Youth Page 6 for the group to see on

My biggest
disappointment since the
pandemic began is . . .



OUR ONE TRUE HOPE



your video call. Form two or three teams to compete while figuring out the phrases. Much like the TV show *Wheel of Fortune*, teens will guess one letter at a time to complete the puzzle. Roll the dice to begin each team's turn. If the dice turns up odd (1, 3 or 5), teams do not get to guess a letter. If the dice turns up even (2, 4 or 6), then the team gets to guess a letter or guess the whole phrase. If the team guesses a letter correctly, write it on the page. Then that same team rolls the dice again. If the team doesn't guess a correct letter, then it must wait until its next turn. A team only gets to guess the answer to the puzzle at its own turn. (ANSWERS: *Round One—Hunger Relief; Round Two—Coronavirus Stimulus Bill*)

Afterwards, read aloud the Scripture and present the commentary in Talk Topic 2 of Teacher Bible Prep before asking and discussing the questions provided there. In addition, ask the following questions to keep the conversation rolling:

- ▶ Do you think it's dangerous to place hope in the wrong things?
- ▶ What's the difference between hope and expectation?
- ▶ How can we make sure our hope is grounded in Christ?

Conclude by saying: "Life always will bring us disappointments, and we always will face challenges and experience loss. But singing songs (like the one in the Psalms) about our hope in God reminds us of the truth of God's steadfast love."

BONUS SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

Invite teens to search online for Kristian Stanfill's song, "Day After Day" (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qYW3eTORZ9Y>). Suggest everyone listen to the song on his or her device (or play using only your device if the sound is sufficient). Say: "Similar to King David's psalm that we just discussed, let's listen to a more modern song about hope." Afterwards, ask and talk about the following:

- ▶ What message did you hear from the song?
- ▶ One line in the song says, "You are Lord both now and forever."

Those words are a good reminder for us. How would you explain this phrase considering what we are experiencing now?

- ▶ Why is hope essential?
- ▶ What are other songs that help you stay hopeful right now?

Talk Topic 3: Lean In (15–20 minutes)

Combined Middle School and High School Option

Ahead of time, compile a list of stressors you think might be experienced by your students (lack of toilet paper, need more space, want to exercise more, tired of eating the same food for breakfast, need more exam prep (for AP or ACT), missing fun summer plans, want to see friends in person and not just through Zoom, and so on). Invite teens to hold up one hand (or two hands for a longer game) so others can see. Then, as you read aloud stressors from your list, ask students to raise one finger for each statement that applies to them. The first teen to raise five fingers (or 10) will be the winner.

Transition from the game by saying: "Whether you realize it or not, whether we admit it or not, we are all stressed. Now more than ever we need to lean in on our faith and trust in God. We need to place our worries and burdens at Jesus' feet, even though it's much easier said than done. It takes practice to let go and focus more on the ever-present love of God. Let's look at an invitation from Jesus in the Book of Matthew. Read aloud the final Scripture, present the commentary, and talk about the questions in Talk Topic 3's Teacher Bible Prep. Then enhance the discussion by asking the following questions:

- ▶ Has it been easier or more difficult to pray during these past few weeks?
- ▶ How can we change our priorities to reflect Jesus as our true hope?
- ▶ In what ways can we help one another lean into God more and more?
- ▶ Do you feel at peace with God? If not, what can you do to move in the right direction?

TAKE AWAY

It's not enough to say this season will eventually end. We must place our hope in the Creator, Redeemer, and Sustainer and find peace in God.

WORKING IT OUT

WHEEL OF MISFORTUNE



ROUND ONE - CATEGORY: Philanthropy

ROUND TWO - CATEGORY: Pandemic



Inherit the Mirth



In the Bible: Readings for the Week

MONDAY: Read Proverbs 3:5-6.

Holy God, help me fully trust in you with all my heart.

TUESDAY: Read Psalm 27:1-5, 14.

What does safety in God truly mean?

WEDNESDAY: Read Philippians 4:4-7.

God, help me bring all my needs to you in prayer today, while still giving you my thanks and praise.

THURSDAY: Read Psalm 43:1-5.

Where am I placing my hope today?

FRIDAY: Read Matthew 6:25-34.

What am I most worried about today, and how can I give that over to God?

SATURDAY: Read Psalm 33:13-22.

Day after day, moment by moment, Lord, let your faithful love surround us.

WHAT'S TRENDING?

What do you miss most about your normal life? Tweet or post your response with the hashtag #lettinggo on Twitter to @YMPartners or on facebook.com/youthministypartners